

Microraptor

Only slightly larger than a pigeon, *Microraptor* (“tiny thief”) is one of the smallest known dinosaurs. It was completely covered with feathers and could fly (or at least glide) from tree to tree, sailing on what appear to be four wings. A member of the dromaeosaur family, *Microraptor* was a carnivore and a close relative of *Velociraptor*, but it wasn’t a true bird.

Microraptor

MY-crow-rap-tor

- **When** 130–125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Probably small mammals, lizards, and insects

Scientists have found dozens of fossils of *Microraptor* in China, including more than 20 well-preserved skeletons. Unlike a bird, this creature had teeth, a bony tail, and front legs with large claws, but its fossils also show unmistakable signs of flight feathers, proving that feathers are not a unique feature of birds but were found in other dinosaurs too. *Microraptor* didn’t have the big flight muscles needed to take off by flapping, but it could have used its wings for gliding, much like a flying squirrel. Its tail had a diamond-shaped fan of feathers at the end, perhaps to steady it in midair. The long feathers on its feet would have gotten in the way when walking or running, so perhaps *Microraptor* stayed in the trees.

